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problems, including those due to its geography, local language, and social conditions. A strong local FOSS community can ensure that these issues are resolved faster, removing barriers to the adoption of FOSS, and thus increasing users' (and potential users') confidence in FOSS. This is true of India as well, and it is critical for us to be strong on the FOSS production front.

The good news is that India has a growing FOSS community. However, there are issues like community efforts being scattered, or not being in tune with Indian needs, and sometimes even lacking in consistency.

The nascent Indian community

The Indian FOSS community is still small, because technology companies, developers and other stake-holders like educational institutes are still developing the culture of contributing back to the community. "The efforts of user groups are not unified, nor is the community well-structured. The community spirit is yet to take root in educational institutes," says Bhavsar.

Satish Mohan, director, Software Engineering, Red Hat Software Services (India), adds, "India has rather unique technological needs, ...due to a range of issues from diversity of languages to infrastructure gaps. Thus, there is a need for Indian contributors to solve such indigenous

problems. For instance, a while back, Mozilla Firefox had problems with printing in the Indic locale, and it required Indian contributors to step forward to fix the problem. We did resolve the issue eventually, but it took more time than it would have if we had a more active base of contributors in India."

Bacche attributes the community participation problem to the socio-economic context in India. "When it comes to community contribution, India's presence is pretty nascent; part of the reason is the socio-economic context that our engineers live in. If we look at software engineers in the US, they can easily decide to take a sabbatical and contribute solely to the community. They do not look for a salary or inspiration, as the spirit to contribute is deep-rooted in them, and contributing to the community is a career for many. In India, most engineers would like to contribute back and build a community however as additional work, rather than a career. The socio-economic context plays a major role in building a healthy community and to establish the FOSS supply and demand chain."

So what is expected of stake-holders like technology companies and technology associations, many of whom are still quiet about their involvement with FOSS? "There is a need for them to come out in the open and publicly affirm their support for the FOSS community. Industry associations



"Just the implementation of a policy that mandates the use of FOSS in large government projects will spur the demand and consumption of FOSS."

Shan Kadavil, country manager, Zynga (India)